tirement to his final match, a doubles in which he partnered Rafael Nadal, as a way to tell the story of his career.

Except, *Federer*, despite the "access" Kapadia's co-director Sabia had to make what was supposedly intended to be a private film, never gets past the image of Federer as uber executive. The documentary, Kapadia says, is "consciously not an attempt to tell Federer's life story". It's interesting, Kapadia insists, "because it isn't the life story. He [Federer] is not ready for that yet. I think he will do it and I think he's gonna have a lot to say, but this is just about the end of your career and the emotion that comes with the fact that it's all over." It explains the ponderously elegiac note the film strikes (and keeps striking).

What rescues *Federer* from tedium is the presence of Nadal, his entry timed relatively late in the film for dramatic effect. Without Nadal, the Federer story is one of uncomplicated superiority. As Andy Roddick put it, after being beaten by Federer—"I threw the kitchen sink at him, but he went to the bathroom and got his tub." Nadal, for a time, was the only man who could beat Federer, including memorably on Federer's own turf at Wimbledon in 2008, arguably the greatest tennis match ever. It forced Federer to deal, as he admits in the film, psychologically and emotionally with the fact of having a nemesis. In the end, both men rose above competition, proving that rivalries can be fierce yet tender. Nadal's tearful grief over Federer's retirement is the beating heart of the documentary.

Kapadia set out to make a "small film about a big guy". But *Federer: Twelve Final Days* mistakes smallness for shallowness. There is so much about Federer that is extraordinary, so much that is engaging—instead of letting that balletic game do the talking though, Kapadia settles for a message from Federer Inc, for corporate gloss when what at least this Federer fan wanted was poetry. ■

–Shougat Dasgupta

OTT

TWISTS IN THE TALE

JioCinema's cop drama *Gaanth Chapter 1: Jamnaa Paar* is a fictionalised account of the 2018 Burari deaths



Gaanth Chapter 1: Jamnaa Paar is the latest excursion into the 2018 ritualistic mass suicide of 11 members of a family in Northeast Delhi's Burari area. Creator Soham Bhattacharya, with writers Anagh Mukherjee and Fahim Irshad, spins a cop drama out of the infamous incident, hedging bets on a simple question: was it suicide or murder?

Out on JioCinema in June, *Gaanth* follows Manav Vij as angry cop Gadar Singh, who is investigating the deaths, along with psychiatry intern Sakshi Murmu, whose savant syndrome allows her to cut through the clutter and see patterns in the crime everybody else is missing.

Gaanth is one of the better Delhi NCR-set cop dramas that have come on the heels of Sudip Sharma's *Pataal Lok*. The visual and social world of *Gaanth* is oppressive. Gloomily lit frames communicate the complex web of politics and social codes that Gadar and Sakshi must untangle to get to the bottom of the mystery.

"My first impression of East Delhi and beyond, past the Yamuna floodplains, was a sense of violence," Mukherjee recalls about his student days in the capital. His explorations of Delhi as a photographer lend material to the writing.

Irshad himself has had disturbing experiences in the region, which witnessed violent riots in 2020. "I remember I was in Shahdara, looking for a place called Masjid wali gali," says Irshad. "At a shop, a young man snarled at me saying this is Hindustan, where you have only Mandir wali gali, no Masjid wali gali. When I protested, they laughed." This social context is embedded deeply in *Gaanth*, where among the primary players are a Hindu right-wing outfit.

Gaanth had a six-year journey from script to screen. Research included meeting psychiatric and forensic experts, cops who have worked on mass deaths, and residents of East Delhi.

"Interestingly, every single person had their own version of the 2018 mass deaths," says Bhattacharya. "These overlapping subsets filled the gaps in our story. There was no one true narrative." In fact, the writers had titled the show *Parallax*, as it communicated a *Rashomon*-style multi-perspective look at the crime.

Early episodes of *Gaanth* hinge on the occult angle, giving the series a quasi-supernatural flavour, which is pushed aside for a more grounded approach towards the end. "We didn't want to just do true crime," says Mukherjee. "We wanted to create a story with larger resonance." The trio is tight-lipped about exactly what's in store for *Gaanth Chapter 2*, but you can expect the story of another headline-grabbing crime in recent memory. ■

–Devarsi Ghosh

Early episodes of **GAANTH** hinge on the occult angle, which is later replaced by a grounded approach